

Regular Meeting
May 15, 2017
School Committee Meeting
Council Chambers

The regular meeting of the Medford School Committee was called to order by Mayor Burke in the City Hall Council Chambers at 7:06 p.m. Those present were Ms. Cugno, Ms. DiBenedetto, Ms. Kreatz, Ms. Mustone, Mr. Skerry, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor Burke and Superintendent Belson.

On the motion of Ms. Mustone seconded by Ms. Cugno to suspend the rules to present awards:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Dr. Nicole Chiesa explained that the Boston Globe Scholastic Writing Awards contest is an important opportunity for students to be recognized for their creative talents. All writing pieces are judged on originality, technical skill and the emergence of a personal voice or vision. They are open to students in grades 7-12. Awards were presented to twenty-nine students.

Candace Van Aiken presented the Scholastic Art Awards. She said that this year marked the 94th anniversary for the Scholastic Art and Writing Award sponsored nationally by the nonprofit Alliance for Young Artists & Writers and locally by the Boston Globe and the Globe Foundation. This year more than 15,000 visual art and 3,000 writing works were submitted for consideration. Seven students received awards.

Dr. Chiesa continued with the presentation. She gave a brief overview of the awards including Model UN, State Geography Bee, Arbeiter Holocaust Essay Contest, All State Journalism and National History Day. The accomplished students were presented certificates.

Ms. Van der Kloot thanked all the students and asked the parents to give permission for the student's work to be published on the website for everyone to enjoy.

Director of Science Rocco Cieri presented awards to the winners of the annual Medford High School Science Fair.

Director of Mathematics Carolyn Joy presented award certificates to the Robotics Team who finished second overall out of eighteen teams at the Greater N. E. Regional Botball Tournament.

Superintendent Belson congratulated all of the students stating that Medford is very proud of them. He said look around at the diversity of the students and their achievement. We all work together. Their achievement comes from a collaboration.

On the motion of Ms. Mustone seconded by Ms. Cugno to revert back to regular order of business:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Committee of the Whole – May 10, 2017

Superintendent Belson asked if there were any questions otherwise the minutes can be entered into the record. Ms. DiBenedetto commented that it was a very good meeting. She said that perhaps it was an oversight but there is a secondary agenda item that is not reflected in the meeting regarding the PTO's. Ms. DiBenedetto requested the minutes be amended and brought back at the next meeting for approval.

As amended (see attached) the minutes of the committee of the whole were approved:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Mr. Skerry commented on parent involvement. He would like to see more parent and community involvement.

Ms. Van der Kloot commented on the update regarding B1/B2 visas she said that this is a concern of many, she is happy it is resolved.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Cugno that the minutes of May 1, 2017 be approved:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto that the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved:

Ms. DiBenedetto asked for clarification on three items. Two of the items were explained and the Superintendent will get an answer to the professional/technical line item.

Voted: That the Bills/Transfer of Funds be approved.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot that the Payrolls be approved:

Voted: That the Payrolls be approved

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke

Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Pre Budget – English Language Arts

Director of Humanites Dr. Nicole Chiesa presented the report. Dr. Chiesa reported that the English Language Arts department is dedicated to supporting all teachers in the district who teach this core academic subject. The ELA curriculum is aligned to the *2011 Massachusetts English Language Arts Curriculum Framework* that is based on the Common Core State Standards. Dr. Chiesa continued with an explanation of the use of funding for 2016-2017 and listed the many accomplishments of the school year. She reviewed her budget request for 2017-2018 which includes additional funds of \$17,000 to purchase Study Island and Journey's materials to support Tier 2 and Tier 3 instruction.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto asked Dr. Chiesa that since it was requested by the elementary principals for RTI implementation, what is your opinion. Dr. Chiesa said that she would look at the schedules and see if a block for RTI can be implemented but that the teachers do have the intervention tools that are needed. Ms. DiBenedetto said that she wants to make sure that the students that need Tier 2 and 3 are getting the services. She wants to meet that need. She asked Dr. Chiesa to please look at this prior to budget and would like to hear back.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Kreatz to accept the report and place on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Pre Budget Report: Social Studies

Dr. Chiesa continued with the social studies department. She reported that the social studies department is committed to providing all students with the academic and problem-solving skills essential for personal development, responsible citizenship and lifelong learning.

Dr. Chiesa continued with an explanation of the use of funding for 2016-2017 and listed the many accomplishments of the school year. She reviewed her budget request for 2017-2018 which includes \$16,000 for U.S. History texts and new AP Human Geography texts.

Discussion:

Ms. Van der Kloot asked if the AP Human Geography course is in place of another course. Dr. Chiesa answered that they still have to look at the numbers but it will most likely be an addition.

On the motion of Ms. Kreatz seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot to accept the report and place on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Report on Summer Programs 2017

Deputy Superintendent presented the report. Ms. Nelson said that over the past several weeks administrators have been meeting to plan this year's summer programs. She highlighted each program. The programs include regular summer school, English Language Learners summer program, summer fun program, middle school computer science camp, Medford Vocational Technical High School's Career and Technical Education exploration program, High School 101 and various special education programs. All programs will be held at either Medford High School or the Roberts Elementary School. She noted that all summer school courses will be online except for grades 6 and 7.

Discussion:

Ms. Cugno asked if the cost is the same for online courses. Ms. Nelson answered yes. Ms. Cugno asked if we have numbers for the High School 101 program and is it open to everyone. Ms. Nelson answered that it is not open to everyone because we are unable to accommodate all. When we had the grant it was based on MCAS scores now it is 8th grade teacher recommendation. There are approximately 40 students. Ms. Cugno asked how many students took online courses last summer. Ms. Nelson answered that any student who had to take science but she would get the exact numbers for Mr. Blauch. Ms. Mustone asked about the Newcomers program and if there is transportation/cost. Ms. Nelson replied that it is a free program. Ms. Van der Kloot inquired about students on free and reduced lunch and if they receive a reduction in tuition. Ms. Nelson commented that we work with parents if they need payment plan we comply. We take it case by case but no one is turned away. Ms. DiBenedetto questioned the Mayor regarding the summer recreation book if it is available and where? Mayor Burke informed all that it went to print today and will be distributed to the schools and available at the library and city hall.

On the motion of Ms. Van der Kloot seconded by Ms. Cugno to accept the report and place on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

Report on English Language Learners Newcomers Program Redistribution

Superintendent Belson reported that the substantial growth of newcomer English Language students at the elementary level requires that we implement a redistribution of this population. The Roberts Elementary School currently serves all "newcomer" EL students grades 1 thru 5. The last report showed that there were 66 newcomer students at that site. Additional students are arriving on a regular basis. The Roberts has 585 total students enrolled as of this date. In order to alleviate the concentration of "newcomer" students to the Roberts, we are planning to shift approximately 25-30 1st and 2nd grade students to the Brooks Elementary School. A shift of this type will also increase the

overall diversity of the Brooks consistent with our balance plan. The current total enrollment at the Brooks is 497 students. The shift of students will also balance the overall enrollments at both the Roberts and the Brooks. There will be a staffing shift to accommodate the transfer from the Roberts to the Brooks. We do not anticipate any additional cost. Since there is substantial transportation to both schools, we expect only minor route changes for our buses. The only downside to this shift will be that some families will have students in two separate elementary schools. This reality is currently true when some families have students in specialized programs. We believe that this is manageable. Both Principals have been consulted and there is sufficient space at the Brooks to accommodate the additional students.

Discussion:

Ms. DiBenedetto said this is a great idea especially for class size and space. She would like to watch it next year to see if it causes any hardship to these families. Superintendent Belson said that he can't make everyone happy all the time. This year it is elementary next year we will have to look at redistribution at the middle schools. Not everyone will be happy in the transition. Ms. Van der Kloot said the biggest concern is that the older students are usually in charge of the younger one which can create issues. Superintendent Belson said that we will begin to reach out to families this week to help them with arrangements.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot to accept the report and place on file:

Vote:

Yes: 7
No: 0
Absent: 0

New Business:

School Committee Resolution

Be it resolved, that the Medford School Committee express its sincere condolences to the family of Reverend Edward Doughy. "Father Ed" was the pastor of the Collaboration of St. Francis and St. Joseph Churches in Medford.

Ms. DiBenedetto requested that the annual review of the Superintendent be scheduled.

On the motion of Mr. Skerry seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot the meeting was adjourned at 8:50 p.m.

Roll Call:

Yea: 7 Cugno, DiBenedetto, Kreatz, Mustone, Skerry, Van der Kloot, Burke
Nay: 0
Absent: 0

Respectfully submitted:

Paulette Van der Kloot
Secretary

